

Forward Deployed Product Manager — Scenario Brief

Send to candidates 48 hours before the panel. Everything below can be shared.

Choose Your Scenario

You may use the example scenario below, or bring your own. If you're more comfortable representing a different industry or business function — manufacturing, legal, HR, customer success, or any other — work from that instead. The scenario you choose doesn't change what we're evaluating because we want to understand your approach and thought process. .

Example Scenario — Meridian Capital Services

Meridian Capital Services is a PE-backed investment management services firm, \$195M revenue, 380 employees. Their PE sponsor acquired the business 11 months ago with an explicit "AI-enabled operations" mandate as part of the value creation thesis.

The FP&A team has eight analysts. They own monthly close, budget-vs-actuals reconciliation, variance analysis, management reporting, and the quarterly board narrative. Six months ago, the company purchased Claude enterprise licenses for the full organization. The finance team attended a mandatory one-hour orientation. Adoption since then: near zero.

This is not a story of people who tried and failed. The team is genuinely heads-down — the cadence of monthly close, quarterly board prep, and management reporting leaves little slack. When asked about AI, the response is consistent: *"I just don't see how it applies to what we do. Our work is numbers-based and requires judgment."*

The Director of FP&A, David Okafor, has tried a few prompts on his own. Results were mixed. He isn't resistant — he's genuinely uncertain about where to start, and he doesn't have the bandwidth to figure it out independently. He hired Caylent because the PE sponsor made "AI-enabled finance function" a board-level initiative. The definition of what that means is still wide open.

You have a kickoff call with David and two of his analysts tomorrow.

Bringing your own scenario

If you'd prefer to work in a domain you know better, invent a company and team. Keep the core problem consistent: a knowledge worker team with access to AI tools but near-zero adoption, a team lead who's uncertain rather than resistant, and an executive sponsor expecting results.

What to Prepare

Prepare a short presentation — 5 to 8 slides — that walks through your thinking on the engagement. A strong deck is not a summary of the brief; it's a structured point of view. We use it to evaluate both what you think and how you communicate: slide structure, information density, and how you move from situation to recommendation.

Come ready to present in about 15 minutes. We'll Q&A directly after, then move to a live AI walkthrough.

At minimum, your deck should address:

- **The actual problem.** The team says AI isn't relevant to their work. Is that a legitimate read or a misread — and what does your answer change about your approach?
- **The team lead.** They're not resistant, but they're not a champion either. What do they need from you in the first two weeks?
- **The discovery motion.** This team can't see their own pain because the workload they carry has always been there. How do you surface it — and how do you design a discovery session that creates the "this is actually relevant to me" moment?
- **The first 30 days.** What are you doing, and why in that order?

Live Demo

Come prepared to open your AI setup and show us how you used it to work through this prompt. You'll have 8 minutes to walk the panel through your workflow — what you prompted, how you iterated, and the choices you made. This is not a tool proficiency test, we want to see how you think and work.